

Chapter 139-1

Her emotions were quite complex, come to think of it.

Before she could even calm down her anxiety and unease, she was subjected to Xu Qingzhu's differential treatment.

Liang Shi even briefly had the thought that it would have been better not to come back.

But it was only for an instant.

And she vented all her anxiety and unease in bed.

Xu Qingzhu still couldn't escape crying.

The soft, broken whimpers sounded like a cat whose tail had been stepped on. The hotel bed sheets had a very light lavender scent, and the room was mixed with too many smells.

The sun quickly set, disappearing behind the mountains. The lights of this city lit up in an instant.

Because they were on a high floor, they could even see the lights on the tallest building in this city—they were orange.

Xu Qingzhu's back pressed against the remote control, and the TV actually turned on.

However, the TV's homepage was playing an advertisement.

As luck would have it, it was an advertisement for Minghui Jewelry's winter new products endorsed by Yang Shuyan, being broadcast on TV.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were both stunned at the same time.

Xu Qingzhu came back to her senses even slower than Liang Shi. After a moment, Liang Shi pinched Xu Qingzhu's waist and blew into her ear: "Am I better looking or is she?"

Xu Qingzhu's response was half a beat slow.

Liang Shi didn't let her off.

Xu Qingzhu was in completely different states during her heat period versus normal times.

During her heat period, she was extremely clingy.

But once her heat period passed, she acted as if she wanted to cut off all ties with you—no one could stand it.

Clearly, when she left in the morning, she had pulled Liang Shi by the collar to ask for a kiss. Even when she was about to be late for an important meeting, she could still steal a moment to give her a kiss.

But by evening, she would ask "what's wrong with you?" in that extremely cold tone.

And it was repeated over and over.

Seeing that Liang Shi was unhappy, she didn't try to coax her either. The difference in treatment from those few days was too obvious.

Liang Shi felt like she was just a tool for Xu Qingzhu to get through her heat period.

It might not even be an illusion.

So she poured all these feelings of unease and grievance into a grand intimate affair.

After Xu Qingzhu's heat period, she became even more unrestrained.

After all, outside of an Omega's heat period, the probability of pregnancy was less than 1%.

From when the sun set in the west to when the moon hung high in the sky, the two finally took a quick shower and lay on the bed.

Xu Qingzhu lay at the edge, eyes closed pretending to sleep, looking as if she didn't want to pay any attention to Liang Shi.

After venting her emotions, Liang Shi knew she was in the wrong. While showering, she had also seen the bruises on Xu Qingzhu's body and felt remorseful and self-reproachful.

Although Xu Qingzhu was the type whose skin marked easily at the slightest touch, fundamentally speaking, she had still gone too far.

She also hadn't been as gentle as usual.

However, Xu Qingzhu outside of her heat period gave people a different kind of wicked pleasure.

There was a huge contrast between her during heat and normally. During heat, she cried when feeling good, and cried when it hurt.

But when not in heat and not affected by an Alpha, her expression was cool and detached. Even when her desire was aroused, at most the corners of her eyes would be slightly red.

Cool and abstinent.

As if she didn't care about such matters at all.

It made it seem like Liang Shi was being one-sided, forcing herself on her.

But when Liang Shi was about to give up, she would grab Liang Shi's arm and say with a hooked smile: "Chickening out?"

If it were during heat, she would definitely cling tightly, snuggling and nuzzling in her arms, crying pitifully: "Jiejie."

Or saying aggrievedly: "Jiejie~ Help me."

So delicate and soft.

But right now, she just instinctively aroused one's desire to conquer.

Those two words coming from her mouth didn't count as provocation—it was as if she were stating a fact in an offhand manner.

Even though it was a question.

Liang Shi's competitive spirit, which had faded to almost nothing, was stirred up. She went back at it, saying through gritted teeth: "Don't you dare cry."

Xu Qingzhu laughed: "Not necessarily."

Even in this kind of matter, she appeared composed and at ease.

Facing such a person, Liang Shi naturally forgot to show mercy.

Before, she had treated Xu Qingzhu like a porcelain doll, afraid of bumping or dropping her.

But today her defenses had been broken down, retreating step by step.

Only after it ended did she realize she had completely followed Xu Qingzhu's rhythm.

Xu Qingzhu had made Liang Shi lose her head with just a few words.

One could only say it was quite crazy.

But after the craziness, one always had to clean up one's own mess. There was no smile on Xu Qingzhu's cool face.

Chapter 139-2

When Liang Shi came out after her shower, she squatted by the bed and said in a low voice: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes opened slightly, her tone lazy: "Hmm?"

Liang Shi gave a low cough: "Are you hungry?"

Much gentler than she had been in bed just now.

Her arrogant demeanor seemed to have been extinguished by water in an instant—she was extremely docile now.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes had already regained their clarity. The hotel's large bed had been messed up and wrinkled beyond recognition.

"I'm okay." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi asked again: "Then are you thirsty?"

Xu Qingzhu's eye corners lifted upward. "What are you trying to say?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"I'm just simply asking..." Liang Shi couldn't bring herself to finish, feeling guilty. She lay prone at the edge of the bed, her hair pressed under her arm, and leaned over to kiss Xu Qingzhu. "Don't be angry."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her.

After a moment, she reached out a finger and poked her forehead. "Dummy."

There was laughter in her words.

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu sat up, her long hair scattered over her back. She hadn't put on anything after showering and had just casually draped the blanket over herself.

Although there was fatigue on her face, there was more of a languid smile.

"Liang Shi." Xu Qingzhu spoke: "Why can't I get closer to Sun Chengcheng?"

When she asked, there was still no fluctuation in her voice, yet it made one feel a sense of pressure.

"What happened when you went to see Chen Liuying?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "Why don't you tell me anything?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"Nothing." Liang Shi denied instinctively.

Xu Qingzhu still had that languid appearance, but her tone was very certain. "You were very uneasy today."

Their eyes met.

Xu Qingzhu's fingertip fell on her lower eyelid. "What are you anxious about?"

Very suddenly, in that instant, Liang Shi let go of all her unease.

The heart that had been hanging in suspense finally settled back down.

Liang Shi let out a soft breath and said earnestly: "I thought you... didn't like me anymore."

So she wanted to desperately use her body to hold onto the memories.

To use those things to reassure herself.

Xu Qingzhu laughed when she heard this, laughing until she buried her whole self into the blanket.

Liang Shi watched her, at a loss.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally stopped laughing. She leaned against the edge of the bed, the blanket almost sliding off.

That cool voice called out: "Liang Shi, come here."

Liang Shi slowly moved closer.

Xu Qingzhu leaned over and lightly bit her lips. "The person who bullied you has come right to our doorstep. I have to get revenge for you."

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu blinked at her, not caring about what state she herself was in.

She directly pulled her down.

After the passionate kiss ended, Xu Qingzhu guided Liang Shi's hand to rest over her heart. "Feel it."

Liang Shi still hadn't come back to her senses.

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "It's beating so fast for you."

Chapter 139-3

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On the way back that night, Liang Shi even played very sweet songs on the car stereo.

It was also on the way back that she learned that Xu Qingzhu had already known who Sun Chengcheng was while she was in a coma.

Sun Chengcheng approaching her was probably just to build a good relationship. Although she didn't know why Sun Chengcheng wanted to do that, Xu Qingzhu was playing along with her scheme.

Liang Shi actually didn't quite agree with her approach. For someone like that, Liang Shi would rather have her stay far away.

But Xu Qingzhu smiled and said: "Whether it's a tiger or a cat, it's always safer to keep them by your side."

Liang Shi: "?"

"It's easier to put a cage on her." Xu Qingzhu said.

So that's why Xu Qingzhu had sent Liang Shi a message telling her not to come out and not to meet Sun Chengcheng face to face.

But Liang Shi said: "It's no use. We'll be working together later anyway."

"But she doesn't know I'm also the one from before." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu nodded upon hearing this: "Then remember to hide it well."

Liang Shi: "?"

"This kind of thing—closing the door to beat the dog."¹ Xu Qingzhu said: "I'm quite good at it."

She was clearly talking about the tactics commonly used by capitalists.

Usually, these were things Liang Shi had looked down upon before, thinking that those who played schemes were dirty.

But when these words came out of Xu Qingzhu's mouth, Liang Shi only found her cute.

No matter what she did, she was cute.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't eat out. Although Xu Qingzhu was already starving, tomorrow was a rare day off, so she wanted to indulge a little tonight.

It had been too long since she'd eaten Liang Shi's cooking, so tonight she wanted Liang Shi to cook. She didn't mind that they wouldn't be able to eat until the early morning hours.

So the two of them stopped by the supermarket on the way.

It was the first time they had gone grocery shopping together.

Xu Qingzhu grabbed a lot of snacks. Liang Shi was pushing the small cart beside her, looking at all those high-calorie foods in surprise: "You're going to eat all of these tonight?"

"Not necessarily able to finish them all." Xu Qingzhu said: "But I am eating them tonight."

"They're all puffed snacks." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu shrugged indifferently: "It's not like I'll get fat."

Liang Shi: "....."

So she didn't prepare any for her?

"What should we drink tonight?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "Alcohol or soft drinks?"

"Alcohol." Liang Shi said.

So Xu Qingzhu grabbed a bottle of red wine from the shelf.

Liang Shi looked at vegetables and fruits, filling up a small cart full.

When it came time to pay, Liang Shi was about to do it, but Xu Qingzhu beat her to it.

Liang Shi carried the bags with one hand and held her with the other as they left the supermarket.

"Why do you have to compete even over paying?" Liang Shi teased her: "President Xu is rich, isn't she?"

"I suppose so." Xu Qingzhu slid her fingers through the gaps between Liang Shi's fingers. The wind blew toward them, but she didn't feel cold at all.

Xu Qingzhu leaned closer to Liang Shi's side. "I still have enough money to support my jiejie."

Liang Shi: "....."

"I have money." Liang Shi said: "I can support you."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Huh? How much?"

Liang Shi's eyes rolled, her voice very low: "About two hundred or so."

"How much?" Xu Qingzhu pretended not to hear.

"About two hundred." Liang Shi repeated.

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment. "Then what are you going to support me with? Are we going to eat steamed buns and pickled vegetables together?"

Liang Shi laughed at this and pinched her fingers. "Add 'ten thousand' after that."

"That's quite a lot." Xu Qingzhu said: "Teacher Liang has quite a nice nest egg. What are you planning to do with it eventually?"

Liang Shi paused for a moment. "Buy a house, I guess."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"That works too." Xu Qingzhu said: "Should we ask Zhao Xuning to buy the place we're living in now? Or buy a different one?"

"What do you think?" Liang Shi asked her: "Where do you want to live? Anywhere is fine with me."

"Anywhere is fine with me too." Xu Qingzhu rested her head on her shoulder. "Wherever you go, I'll go."

"Really?"

"Even if you go back to that place of yours in the future, I'll find a way to follow you." Xu Qingzhu's cool voice laughed: "Jiejie, are you at ease now?"

Liang Shi: ".....At ease."

"By the way, did you want to come back because of me?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi gave a low cough, too embarrassed to answer directly.

Even though Xu Qingzhu had asked this question many times in bed during her heat period.

But asking it now made Liang Shi's feelings feel somewhat at a loss.

However, after a moment, she still answered firmly: "Yes."

"That's really nice." Xu Qingzhu said: "You got your wish."

Liang Shi: "....."

She had a feeling Xu Qingzhu was complimenting herself.

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1. "Closing the door to beat the dog" (關門打狗) is a Chinese idiom/military strategy meaning to trap someone before attacking them, cutting off their escape route before dealing with them. It's one of the Thirty-Six Stratagems in Chinese military strategy. ⇐

Chapter 139-4

Back at home, Xu Qingzhu sat on the sofa watching TV and eating chips while Liang Shi was cooking in the kitchen.

It was already close to eleven o'clock.

Xu Qingzhu only watched for a few minutes before running to the kitchen. She leaned against the kitchen doorway and asked: "Liang Shi, do you need any help?"

Liang Shi answered without turning her head: "No need. Go watch TV."

Xu Qingzhu walked over and picked up a chip to bring to her mouth.

Liang Shi looked at it and frowned—she had already converted this thing into calories.

She didn't open her mouth for a long time.

Xu Qingzhu urged her: "Hurry up."

"I'm joining the crew soon." Liang Shi said: "The new character is a very thin person."

Xu Qingzhu coaxed her: "It's just one chip. It won't matter."

Liang Shi: "....."

Swayed, Liang Shi opened her mouth. Xu Qingzhu smiled mischievously, and after Liang Shi swallowed the chip, she patted her shoulder. "Teacher Liang, your five-kilometer run tomorrow is waiting for you."

Liang Shi: "....."

"You're so mean." Liang Shi smiled helplessly yet indulgently.

While Liang Shi was turning around, Xu Qingzhu directly burrowed into her arms and raised her hand to feed her more food.

Liang Shi had no choice but to eat it all.

Xu Qingzhu happened to be embraced by Liang Shi in front of the kitchen counter, basically blocking her view.

This was what happened when there wasn't much of a height difference.

Liang Shi smelled the scent from the ends of her hair and lowered her head to sniff again: "You should still use your own shampoo. The hotel shampoo doesn't smell good."

"There wasn't any at the time." Xu Qingzhu said, then suddenly paused, her tone dangerous: "Liang Shi, why do you carry your ID card with you?"

Liang Shi: ".....To see....."

Before she could finish, Xu Qingzhu interrupted: "Are you secretly improper?"

Liang Shi: "?"

She defended herself: "How so? I'm a proper person."

"What proper person carries their ID card with them at all times?" Xu Qingzhu said with conviction. "What proper person takes someone to a hotel before it's even dark?"

In this regard, Liang Shi always came out on the losing end.

But Liang Shi turned her face and bit Xu Qingzhu's cheek.

Xu Qingzhu was startled. "What are you doing?"

"Improper people like to eat meat." Liang Shi said, throwing caution to the wind.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"Then are you still going to eat dinner?" Xu Qingzhu asked faintly.

"If I don't eat dinner, am I supposed to eat you?" Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "Huh?"

Liang Shi sucked on her earlobe, making Xu Qingzhu shiver.

Liang Shi said: "If eating you could fill me up, then what would you eat?"

Liang Shi hugged her for a moment, then pulled her out of her arms. "Teacher Xu, even absurdity should have limits."

Xu Qingzhu stood to the side watching her.

Liang Shi said very seriously: "Even lustful thoughts need prerequisites... one must be warm and full first."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"Can't have you passing out halfway through." Liang Shi pinched her ear. "That would make me look like too much of a jerk."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu sighed. "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi: "Hmm?"

Xu Qingzhu: "Maybe I should take back saying I like you. You can go back to being anxious."

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu bit into a chip with a crunch and gave her a sidelong glance: "You're really suited for being single."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Have you ever filmed romance dramas?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "The idol drama kind."

Liang Shi nodded: "A little bit."

Xu Qingzhu was genuinely puzzled: "How did you deliver your lines? Like, convincing yourself those characters were real."

Liang Shi: ".....I've never played a traditional sweet romance female lead."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together with an expression of "this child is beyond teaching."
"When you have time, take on a few of those kinds of projects. Hopefully you'll get a clue."

Liang Shi: ".....My new movie is kind of like that."

"Gu Yixue's?"

"Yes."

"The female lead is Sun Chengcheng?"

"Right."

"Then forget it." Xu Qingzhu said: "I don't like her."

Liang Shi: ".....Then who do you like? Yang Shuyan?"

Xu Qingzhu: "That's not entirely out of the question. When can you reach that level of stardom? Do an idol drama with her."

Liang Shi: "....."

After a moment, Liang Shi said quietly: "Kiss scenes and bed scenes are standard in idol dramas, and they don't use body doubles."

Xu Qingzhu's footsteps heading out of the kitchen suddenly stopped.

Liang Shi pressed on: "Do you still want me to act in one?"

She saw Xu Qingzhu clench her fist, then turn around: "Come home, and I'll act it out with you."

Liang Shi couldn't help but laugh quietly.

However.....

She remembered that Xu Qingzhu was also someone who had never dated before. Why did she catch on so quickly?

Liang Shi asked her: "Exactly how many idol dramas have you watched?"

Xu Qingzhu held up two fingers.

"Twenty?" Liang Shi guessed.

After all, Xu Qingzhu was busy with work.

Xu Qingzhu said lazily: "Over two hundred. I finished them while reading documents at the same time."

Liang Shi: "....."

The world of academic overachievers was truly terrifying.

Chapter 139-5

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Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu's life had completely gotten on track.

She didn't know when Lu Jiayi from the original book would appear. Even though she already knew the original story, many things had already been disrupted now, so it had no reference value.

Liang Shi convinced herself to cherish the present.

Even if Lu Jiayi appeared later, she could still put up a fight.

So what if she was a perfect paper character?

As long as Xu Qingzhu didn't like her, no amount of perfection would be useful.

Liang Shi had contacted Gu Yixue. "Heart's Journey" would begin preparations for filming in a week.

As for "Erta Light," due to the issue with the female lead, setting a new date was indefinitely postponed. After all, Zhao Ying had already joined the next production crew and was also doing promotions for two dramas.

While waiting for "Heart's Journey" to start filming, Liang Shi went to see Yang Jiani.

There wasn't much to say. She only asked about what happened with Qiu Zimin back then, which counted as collecting some testimony for the original owner.

Even though this had happened to herself.

After meeting with Yang Jiani, she contacted Chen Mian.

Chen Mian had stayed in Haizhou City to prepare for an art exhibition, but these were all matters for the organizers—she wasn't very involved.

She had simply stayed in Haizhou City. It was hard to say whether she was waiting for Yang Jiani's verdict or trying to find traces of Qi Jiao's existence in this city.

This time they didn't meet at a café. Chen Mian directly sent her a location near a middle school.

Liang Shi drove there following the navigation and found it was the middle school the original owner had attended—also Qi Jiao's alma mater.

Chen Mian's home was on the fifth floor, with no elevator.

It was a rather old building, which surprised Liang Shi quite a bit.

Liang Shi had bought fruit when she went. When Chen Mian came to open the door and saw the fruit in her hands, she frowned.

Liang Shi asked what was wrong.

Chen Mian said very bluntly: "I don't like apples."

Liang Shi: "....."

The furnishings in Chen Mian's home were somewhat simple. Sky-blue walls, just a sofa on the floor, no coffee table. The kitchen was semi-open, and there was a studio, a bedroom, and a bathroom.

For one person living alone, it was still fairly spacious.

Before Liang Shi came in, Chen Mian had probably been painting.

She was holding a paintbrush in her hand, and there was paint on her black T-shirt.

But after Liang Shi entered, Chen Mian set the paintbrush aside.

The only thing the two of them could talk about was Qi Jiao, though Chen Mian asked about her previous coma.

The words "Qi Jiao" were right on the tip of her tongue, but Liang Shi didn't know how to bring it up.

She couldn't decide in that moment which would be crueler for Chen Mian—that Qi Jiao had passed away, or that Qi Jiao was living well in another world but the two of them would never see each other again.

So Liang Shi didn't mention it.

Without mentioning Qi Jiao's current situation, Liang Shi felt her trip here was completely meaningless.

She and Chen Mian weren't exactly close friends or confidants who could share heartfelt words.

When neither of them spoke, it felt very awkward.

Though it was probably only Liang Shi who felt awkward.

Chen Mian showed no reaction.

After a while, Chen Mian went to the studio and came back with two artistically designed tickets, handing them to her. "This Wednesday at the city art museum."

Liang Shi was startled: "Huh?"

They were tickets to Chen Mian's art exhibition.

Chen Mian said: "I remember you have a younger sister who also studies painting. She should be interested."

Liang Shi glanced at the tickets: "Than—"

The words "thank you" suddenly got stuck in her throat, because she saw written on the ticket

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"Joint Exhibition of Thirteen 'Eccentric Geniuses' Including Chen Mian, Qin Lishuang, Guan Zhi, and Others."